The Backup Care Conversation

How to ask the family who can really be there for your husband.

Your daughter says she'll come whenever you need her. She lives two hours away, and neither of you has said what “whenever” means.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: turn each offer into days and times, or into an honest no. Both are useful. It isn't for deciding what care your husband needs or whether the arrangement will work.

Who should be there

Everyone who has offered to help, and anyone the plan seems to be counting on whether they've offered or not. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team. [1]

The daughter two hours away can join by phone. Someone who can't make it can send their days and times ahead.

Your husband has a say in this too. Whether he sits in or hears about it afterward, ask him who he's comfortable having help him, and write that down. AARP's planning guide says a family plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person receiving the care. [3]

Ask someone other than yourself to keep the notes, so you can listen.

How to open

Bring the day written out in blocks, and a short list of the specific jobs. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that when jobs are broken down into very simple tasks, it is easier for people to help. [2]

Then start with a request. Nobody did anything wrong by saying “I'll help.”

- “There's a date for the change now. I've written out his day in blocks, and I'd like us to put names in them together.”
- “I'm not asking anyone for more than they can give. I'm asking what you can really do, so I'm not guessing.”
- “A no is fine. A no tells me which hours need another answer.”
- Say what the conversation is for: names, days and times. Say what it isn't for: deciding what care he needs.

Questions to ask

Ask your husband

1. Who are you comfortable having help you, and with what?

Ask each person who has offered

1. Which days and which hours can you be there, and is any of that overnight?

2. How long can you keep that up: a few weeks, a few months, until something changes?

3. What are you prepared to do while you're there, and what would you rather not do?

4. If you can't make one of your times, how much notice can you give, and who would you call?

Ask the whole group

1. Looking at the page, which blocks still have nobody in them?

2. Which of the open hours have we all been assuming I would cover?

3. What don't we know yet about when he'll need someone?

How to write down what was said

Write each offer the way the person made it. If it has no day and time yet, leave those boxes empty and don't fill them in on anyone's behalf. A no gets written down too, without comment.

WHO	WHAT THEY SAID	DAYS AND TIMES CONFIRMED	FOR HOW LONG
Our daughter	“I can do every other weekend.”	Every other Friday evening to Sunday at 3	Through December, then she'll say
His brother	“I can't do nights. I can drive him to appointments.”	Weekday appointments, with two days' notice	Didn't say

What not to decide yet

Leave these open. Most of them take an assessment, and the last one isn't a question this conversation needs to answer.

- Whether the arrangement is safe.
- Whether he should come home, or be cared for somewhere else.
- What an open hour means for him.

- Anything about his medications or his care instructions.
- Who ought to be doing more.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the page and send it to everyone.
- Who will take the open hours and the open questions to the discharge planner, the nurse or your care consultant.
- When you'll talk again, since what people can offer changes.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle who should do what, smooth over a disagreement, or tell you what the care team will say about the open hours. It gets every offer onto one page as a day and a time, a no, or a blank.

Ready for the next step?

Your family's offers are now days and times, with the open hours left showing. The care interview takes that page further: it goes through your husband's situation area by area, including who is caring for him and what each person can do, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Asking each person what they are and aren't prepared to do, and checking in again as people's ability to help changes, follows AARP's planning guide. The questions themselves and the page for writing down the answers are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families

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